

TRIP TO THE DISTRICT COURTHOUSE IN HYATTSVILLE, fall 2025 – on Thursday, Nov. 13. Let's meet up just outside the 1st floor lobby of the courthouse, which is at 4990 Rhode Island Ave., Hyattsville, 20781. Please be there NO LATER THAN 9:55 a.m. This is 3 miles from campus, according to Google maps. There is a Metro bus stop in front of the courthouse. The campus shuttle likely has runs down there as well. Give yourself plenty of time to arrive and park.

There is metered parking around the block, and in a Hyattsville parking lot between the government building and the courthouse. Bring quarters and a credit card for the meters. DO NOT attempt to bring food or drink inside. Do not turn your cell phone on inside any courtroom. Do not take photos, video or audio inside any courtroom. Bring a pen and pad to write with. But bring very little inside with you. You will need to go through a security system with metal detectors. Keep your voices low in the hallways, so you do not disturb proceedings inside. We will meet up in the lobby for instructions, before spreading out to sit in court rooms.

Do check the online court docket of cases for Thursday AFTER 9 p.m. on Wednesday. It will show you courtrooms and tentative times for hearings – which will help to guide you on courtrooms to visit. See:

<https://www.mdcourts.gov/sites/default/files/import/district/directories/Dockets/princegeorgeshyattsvilledcdocket.pdf>

Remember that you can look up more info on cases by a defendant's name and case number, here: <https://casesearch.courts.state.md.us/casesearch/> .

INSTRUCTIONS for your assignment: You may use your class notes and PowerPoint from our class discussions, and from the conversations you heard at the courthouse. You may also review a brief video explaining Maryland courts:

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5C-ap8FZLao> , and do Google searches to find answers. But you must work alone. Please type your answers under the questions, OR WRITE LEGIBLY IN INK, and upload your URL to Elms. DUE: 9:59 a.m. Tuesday.

QUESTIONS:

1. If you have a court case that you're following for a story, and you drop by the courthouse a few days before a proceeding, where could you get and review the paper file on the case, to take notes or make copies?

Answer: I can request the physical case file at the Clerk's Office inside the District Courthouse. The clerk will retrieve the paper file from their records room and allow me to view it at the counter or in a designated area. You can take notes or pay for copies of pages. In fact, I tried it myself and received a complaint file for one of the hearings I attended. I though asked for the hearing copy, the official told me it takes at least a week for the documents to arrive their office.

2. How do the physical courthouse files differ from what you can find out about the case online, here, in the Maryland Judiciary Case Search:

<https://casesearch.courts.state.md.us/casesearch/> ?

The online Case Search shows basic information: names, charges, court dates, case history, and summary entries. The paper file should contain more:

- actual complaints and sworn affidavits
- motions and handwritten judge notes
- photographs, inspection reports, and evidence attachments
- correspondence and orders not uploaded online

3. Name three TYPES of cases heard in District Court. (This won't be a complete list.)

- a. Landlord-tenant disputes (rent escrow, breach of contract, evictions)
- b. Domestic violence & protective orders
- c. Traffic and minor criminal cases (misdemeanors)

4. Which courtroom(s) did you sit in on? What cases were heard in each one?

a. Courtroom 6: Judge Sherrie Waldrup

- Hannon Apartments v. Jeffrey Richard Smith

- \$2,911 owed, eviction timeline initiated for Dec 19.

Riverside Plaza case vs Nathan Thapar

- Rats in apartment, sheriff attempted uninformed eviction, tenant disputes repairs. Multiple rent-related disputes for nonpayment from Aug–Nov

b. Courtroom 2 — Judge Llamilet Gutierrez

Erica Munske vs Matthew Sample / Eric Sample

- Plaintiff accuses mold in 3 rooms, ventilation system issues for her delay in escrow payments.
- \$3,000 monthly rent. Rent unpaid for 3 months.
- Defendant argued repairs were made, but the plaintiff disputed.
- The judge sent an inspection order and asked her to pay \$6,000 rent due in Court.
- Address: 6205 Oakridge Road
- Plaintiff requested PG County Police for the inspection instead of University Park Police; however, the judge denied the request.

5. Where else in Prince George's County is there another (state) District Courthouse? (Please don't list the location of a U.S. District Courthouse.)

- The other District Court in Prince George's County is in Upper Marlboro, near the county government complex.

6. Are any jury trials held in District Court? Yes or no?

No. District Court cases are heard only by a judge. Jury trials occur only in Circuit Court.

7. Could any of the proceedings you heard lend themselves to a full story treatment, with additional reporting? Explain in a couple of sentences.

- Not really, not a standalone story-worthy. The cases I observed had some interesting though — like a tenant asking for a different police agency to do an inspection, or another defendant saying the sheriff began an eviction without notifying them. They might be useful as small examples within a bigger trend piece if we can go through a year or two of court cases, and if there is a pattern of accusing one particular agency.

8. Where is the Circuit Courthouse in Prince George's County? What types of cases are heard there? Give at least three examples.

- The Circuit Court is located in Upper Marlboro, at the Prince George's County courthouse complex. There is also a District court.

Types of cases heard there: Felony criminal trials; Major civil cases over \$30,000; Jury trials (if a defendant elects a jury instead of District Court), and Appeals from District Court.

9. Where are the two appeals courts in Maryland – and what are they called?

- Maryland has two statewide appellate courts:

- Appellate Court of Maryland – located in Annapolis
- Supreme Court of Maryland (formerly Court of Appeals) – also in Annapolis

10. What about District Court rules or proceedings surprised you today?

- I was surprised by how informal and fast-paced the proceedings were. Cases moved rapidly, sometimes in less than five minutes, and many tenants or landlords had no legal representation.